

Introduction:

The strongest Civic Education is characterized by a mutual relationship between civic knowledge and civic participation. This is as civic participation gives individuals power, not just practice nor symbolic engagement. Strong civic education can further be implemented as individuals learn what their rights are to make informed decisions. All students should have equal access to a solid civic education and opportunities in schools. Reality is that the traditional model of civic education lacks critical thinking and media literacy skills. It should be able to empower learners to make decisions that will benefit not only themselves, but those around them too. Civic education is not neutral in nature and it should promote strong decision-making and active participation skills. Civic education is most effective especially throughout adolescence, so it is essential to implement these teachings in schools. In the US, Illinois, Florida, Texas, and New Jersey are some examples of some states that have strong civic education models.

Illinois

In Illinois, no civic exam is required but at least one semester of civics is required for graduation. These standards include the teachings of civic and political institutions, participation and deliberation, and processes, rules, and laws. Another section is inquiry skills and Illinois's Inquiry Skills arm students with the skills necessary to lead discourse and bring about equitable change in their communities. Illinois uses an emphasis on rational discourse which gives students a holistic, open minded approach to discourse through the inquiry skills standards. There is also a focus on media literacy in Illinois. The

state government has even partnered with the Illinois Media Literacy Coalition to provide frameworks and resources to inform classroom implementation.

Furthermore, there is a focus on equity for marginalized groups. A major focus of Pritzker and his administration has been striving towards equity and uplifting marginalized voices when possible. The 3rd standard of inquiry skills tasks students with basing their arguments on sources from diverse perspectives, while the 11th inquiry skills task broadly centers around analyzing the impact of policy solutions on all stakeholders, including marginalized communities. Inquiry skills 12, 14, and 15 emphasize taking action to bring about equity in the community. For immigrant and multilingual families there is inclusion in civic education and black and brown youth have more opportunities too. LGBTQ students are in inclusive curricular spaces and disabled students have special education services to help include them in civic education and participation. Meanwhile Civics task 9 partly explores how public policies marginalize certain groups. The LEA provides resources, support, and advocacy for civic education in Illinois. The LEA collaborates with various educational institutions to ensure that students receive high quality civics education.

Illinois has various community components that work together to ensure a strong civic education. The Illinois Civics hub for example provides information on the required implementations of civics classes in Illinois. There is also the center for civic engagement that supports community engagement through classroom experiences to build critical thinking and communication skills. Also, the Illinois Civic Mission Coalition has shaped the state's civic education vision. All of these components add up to provide a strong civic education model for Illinois that is proven through data.

Along the following three categories Illinois consistently ranks above the national average; working with neighbors to do something positive for the community, discussing political/social issues with friends and family, and having a conversation with a neighbor that is a different race as you. The national rate for working with neighbors is 11.9% whereas Illinois has a rate of 16.9%. For discussing political/social issues Illinois has a 67.1% rate whereas the national average is 65.1%. Finally, in having conversations with a different race neighbor Illinois has a rate of 65.7% versus a 53% national average. (CIRCLE, 2022). Clearly, a strong civic education is leading youth generations toward positive improvements in their communities even with something so simple as having a conversation with a neighbor who is not the same race.

New Jersey

In New Jersey, there is the Laura Wooten Law that states that all New Jersey School Districts provide at least two quarters of civics instruction in a middle school grade. The law specifies that the courses should cover principles and ideals underlying the American system of constitutional democracy, functions and limitations of government, and the role of citizens in a democratic society. This also emphasizes critical thinking and active participation. Their framework is based off of standards of developing claims and using evidence, engaging in civil discourse and critiquing conclusion, and taking informed action. Specifically, through taking informed action, youth are able to identify a local issue in the community and come up with a proposed solution and share that with other community members or even officials. Furthermore, New Jersey's LEA support includes the New Jersey Center for Civic Education develops resources and standards for teachers for middle

school civic classes. They collaborate with state civics, government, and law programs. It also offers an Educating for American Democracy roadmap pedagogy companion that aligns to all three levels of “We the People.”

In addition to these civic learning standards the following are mandatorily integrated into social studies; history and contributions of African Americans, highlighting and promoting diversity and inclusion, and Asian American and Pacific Islander history and contributions. In elementary school, a course study in civics is required. In middle school two courses of civics are required. In both middle school and high school political, economic, and social contributions of persons with disabilities and lesbian, gay, bisexual, and transgender people are also taught. Also studying more civics and the US constitution is put into place in High School. These requirements empower marginalized communities and there is a direct push toward equity-centered civic education. For black and brown youth, disabled students, and LGBTQ students there is a focus on equity through their lived experiences and positive contributions to society.

New Jersey offers various resources and organizations that are dedicated to enhancing civic education and community support. Civics NJ empowers young people as stewards of change in their communities. The New Jersey Citizen Action Education Fund is also another resource of community support that looks to empower communities of color and low-moderate income people through direct counseling, research, advocacy, community education, and training on public policy issues. There is also the Northern New Jersey community foundation that improves community life through education, public health, civic engagement, the arts etc. Finally, the Civic and Community Engagement

Center offers resources and programs for active citizenship and democratic participation including community service and political engagement.

With all of these implementations New Jersey has one of the strongest civic education models that is shown consistently. Youth in the state report discussing political issues with family and friends and posting opinions on social media at above-average rates. 18.9% of youth report working with neighbors to do something positive for their community. Just like Illinois, they are also above the national average with an 11.9%. (CIRCLE 2022). Their community-oriented laws and resources have allowed to empower youth to make a positive impact in their communities higher than the national average.

Texas

In 2020, the State of Texas passed a resolution to improve civic education. While students in Texas are required to take both U.S. and Texas history and a semester of U.S. Government to advance their civic knowledge, there remains an insufficient focus on civic skills, attitudes, and behaviors that are critical to a sustained and responsible civic engagement. For grades K-12 Civic knowledge, skills, attitudes, and behaviors are emphasized. Civic knowledge would teach the structure, functions, and processes of our civic institutions at all levels. Civic skills training on how to effectively engage in the civic life and civic institutions of their community and collaboration and community organizing skills. Civic attitudes emphasize the appreciation of the importance and responsibility to participate in civic life. Finally civic behaviors include practicing civic habits, including voting, engaging in deliberative discussions, volunteering, attending public meetings and

participating in other civic activities. Apart from these domains, another standard is Mandating a student-led but curriculum-based, non-partisan civics practicum or project in the 8th grade and once in high school to effectively demonstrate understanding of crucial civic behaviors. Also, Instructing the TEA to infuse civics education into other disciplines by providing content rich, non-fiction civics texts in English Language Arts testing where reading and writing prompts are used and in approved ELA reading lists is another method used.

In Texas, LEA's play a vital role in supporting civic education. The Texas Education Agency offers resources and guidance for LEA's including information on instructional materials funding the EMAT system and the IMRA process. Community components include educational programs like the Civics Training program that educators use to teach civics effectively. The Texas Civic Education Foundation advocates comprehensive civic education and promotes youth voting rights. Curriculum reform and state coordination are also community efforts that aim to support civic education.

Despite their strong civic education plan, young Texans are below the national average for civic and community engagement actions. For instance, 10% of Texans worked with neighbors to do something positive for the community whereas the national average is 11.9%. 60.2% of Texans discussed political or social issues with family whereas the national average is 65.1%. In the past 12 months, 49.3% of Texans have had a conversation with a neighbor of a different race compared to the national average of 53%. Texas has a high youth/adult ratio but a comparatively low rate of associations and of nonprofits per capita. (CIRCLE, 2022). Additionally, Texas Civic education does not well serve the

marginalized communities. In civics, in Texas there are restrictions on DEI and teachings about race or gender. Curriculum often avoids immigrant and black and brown youth and integrating them into civic education opportunities. Disabled students access to civic education varies by district as there are no state mandates in place and LGBTQ students are included with limitations due to laws that do not allow the teachings of certain genders. There is a strong population of multilingual families, but civic integration is not consistent with them either.

Florida

From Kindergarten through Grade 5, Civics and Government instruction progresses from concrete, personal concepts to deeper constitutional understanding. Students begin by learning about rules, authority figures, patriotism and responsible behavior in their immediate environment. In order for a student to be promoted to high school from a school that includes middle grades 6, 7, and 8, the student must successfully complete a one-semester civics education course. Requirements for the standard high school diploma include one credit in United States History and one-half credit in United States Government. Students enrolled in a United States Government course are required to participate in the Florida Civic Literacy Exam. Students entering a Florida College must also demonstrate understanding in Civic Education and Literacy.

Florida's LEA's provides comprehensive support for civic education through various resources. The Civics Literacy Excellence Initiative offers families resources to support Civic Education at home. The Florida Civics and Debate Initiative aims to create access and

opportunities for students and civic education. These National model initiatives alongside local government education, curriculum standards, and instructional guides all make up the community components that effectively improve Florida Civic Education.

Similarly to Texas, they have a strong civic education model but their youth civic engagement is lower than national averages. 6.9% of Floridians have worked with a neighbor to do something positive for their community compared to the national rate of 11.9%. Compared to the national rate of 65.1%, 57.7% of Floridians discussed social or political issues with their family. 23% of Floridians shared news about politics on their social media compared to the national average of 26.1%. (CIRCLE, 2022). Also, Florida Civic Education does not do well to serve marginalized communities. Divisive concepts and laws restricting certain topics do not allow for all social/political issues to be addressed. Teaching about systemic racism is constrained and this limits civic understanding for black and brown youth and immigrants. Disabled students are not fully included, and LGBTQ students are not fully supported and teachings about gender are also restricted thus limiting their civic engagement.

Summary:

Illinois, New Jersey, Texas, and Florida all have strong civic education models with solid LEA support and community components. Despite all having strong civic education, only New Jersey and Illinois have stronger civic engagement in their communities and are above national averages. Texans and Floridians do not seem to be as involved in their communities. Another similarity was that Texas and Florida both have laws in place that

limit marginalized communities from participating in civic engagement opportunities. New Jersey and Illinois on the other hand teach about marginalized communities and use a more equitable teaching approach.

Summary bullet chart of what has worked for each state

Illinois→

Organizations:

-Illinois Media Literacy Coalition

-Illinois Civics Hub

-Center for Civic Engagement

-Illinois Civic Mission Coalition

The Four Non-Negotiables:

Statewide Coherence & Local Implementation: Strong

Real power: Moderate

Hands on Civic Practice: Strong

Strategic Nonviolence: Moderate

New Jersey→

Organizations:

- New Jersey Center for Civic Education
- Educating for American Democracy roadmap
- Civics NJ
- New Jersey Citizen Action Education Fund
- Northern New Jersey Community Foundation
- Civic and Community Engagement Center

The Four Non-Negotiables:

Statewide Coherence & Local Implementation: Strong

Real power: Strong

Hands on Civic Practice: Strong

Strategic Nonviolence: Strong

Texas→

Organizations:

- Civics Training Program

-Texas Civic Education Foundation

The Four Non-Negotiables:

Statewide Coherence & Local Implementation: Strong

Real power: Weak

Hands on Civic Practice: Moderate

Strategic Nonviolence: Weak

Florida→

Organizations:

-Civics Literacy Excellence Initiative

-Florida Civics and Debate Initiative

The Four Non-Negotiables:

Statewide Coherence & Local Implementation: Strong

Real power: Weak

Hands on Civic Practice: Weak

Strategic Nonviolence: Moderate

What do the strongest models share (IL+NJ+MA) that Delaware currently lacks?

Illinois, New Jersey, and Massachusetts all require mandated civics courses for high school education whereas Delaware does not. Delaware has strong anchors that provide guidance on teaching civics, but there is no official mandate with specific curriculum requirements. Also, research has consistently shown that states with strong models of civic education that include marginalized communities actively have higher rates of civic engagement. Delaware also does not serve marginalized communities well, despite attempts at equity. If Delaware implements more resources to include minority communities and implements a mandate for a civics course required for high school graduation, then they will have higher rates of civic engagement across their communities.

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